Holkar and Shinde or Scindhia families who had been loyal to the emperor Shahu, his father Balaji Viswanath and to him.



Bajirao

The Prominent Maratha families

- Gaikwad at Baroda
- Bhonsle at Nagpur
- Holkar at Indore
- Shinde or Scindhia at Gwalior
- Peshwa at Pune

Bajirao proclaimed wars against Malwa and Gujarat and freed them from Mughal domination. The Mughal army and the troops of the Nizam that intervened on behalf of the Mughals were defeated. Bajirao succeeded in getting the recognition of Shahu as the king of Maharashtra and overlord of the rest of the Deccan, from which the tribute of Chauth and Sardeshmukhi could be legally collected by the Maratha officials. Bajirao centralised the fiscal functions in Pune. This helped to receive the prompt transmission of tribute from the Deccan.

The Maratha army, which consisted of no more than 5000 horsemen and no artillery, had by 1720 had doubled in its size. Yet they were no match for the Mughals and the Nizam. The success of Marathas against the Mughals was mainly due to the weakness of the latter. The Maratha dominance in the Deccan is also attributed to the qualities of Maratha officials and generals who grew up under Shahu and the Peshwas.

Balaji Bajirao (1740–1761)



Balaji Bajirao

When Balaji Bajirao was the Peshwa, Emperor Shahu died (1749). A possible succession struggle among factions of the royal family was averted, thanks to the timely intervention of Balaji Bajirao. He summoned all the contending factions and forced them to accept the conditions he laid down. He decided that the capital of the kingdom would henceforward be Pune, not Satara. All power and authority was now concentrated in the Peshwas's office. Balaji Bajirao now commanded an army of paid soldiers. The Maratha peasant warrior band was reconfigured and its run came to an end. Maratha soldiers were not permitted now to retire from battle fields each year for the purpose of cultivating their land. Soldiers were required to live in forts and towns far away from

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